

midlife and eventually retirement. For all it costs to keep a pet alive, happy, and healthy, we should be feeding it a steady diet of shredded cash. Don't even get me started on what it costs to keep that animal clothed. Yes, clothed. I wouldn't call myself an animal lover, but I do have great respect for animals. So I feel their pain when I see them dolled up in dresses and hats, being paraded around wearing an umbrella strapped to a harness. Idiotic.

We see them every year on *Shark Tank*—entrepreneurs with the latest in doggy gadgets and fashions, including neoprene booties and plaid raincoats, doggie diapers and cat boxes that fit on windowsills, pendants that contain your pets' cremains . . . and the list goes on. And every year, I go from being amused at the bulldog on the skateboard to being incensed at the poodle in the stroller. Why? Because there are people out there who will buy these completely asinine gadgets, people who might even carry a lot of debt, who will put shoes on their dogs even if it means spending the last dollar in their pocket. That said, I have admittedly gone into bidding wars for some of the more insidious animal ideas that I know will make big bucks.

Someone once said, "A pet is a short story with a sad ending." I say, "A pet is an *expensive* story, with an *expensive* ending." I'm going to give it to you bluntly: A pet is a phenomenal waste of money. Few people actually consider the cost of a pet *before* getting one. They factor in the fun and affection, but they forget about the food, the license, the leash, the toys, the treats, the poop bags, the dog-walking services, and the vet.

According to the American Society for the Prevention of Cruelty to Animals, which posts a very detailed outline of pet costs on its website, a medium-sized mutt will cost \$1,580, including spaying, in its first year. After that, you're looking at forking over at least \$695 a year in vet, food, treats, and doggie day-care costs. As for cats, their start-up costs are estimated at \$365, and then you pay \$670 a year in kitty upkeep. Consider that cats and dogs live longer than ever before—upward of fifteen years in some cases. That means you should budget more than \$12,000 in a lifetime for the privilege of pet ownership. In fact, there are some surveys that put the lifetime cost of